

BANDEEP SINGH

"The future is in small satellites for observation and communication through small rockets—India has just a two per cent share in this $370 billion business"

PAWAN KUMAR CHANDANA, 31

Co-founder and CEO, Skyroot Aerospace **Hyderabad**

SOARING AMBITION

Choosing one's passion over their ambition can leave most conflicted. Not IITian Pawan Kumar Chandana. He craved the independence of an entrepreneur along with a desire to build rockets. What helped him blend both was a mechanical engineering degree from IIT Kharagpur. Chandana opted for the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) over going abroad for further studies or enrolling in the high-paying finance or information technology fields. "Without any thought, I attended the interview and luckily got selected. I was fortunate to get in despite a comparatively low academic performance—the three others chosen were among the batch toppers," he recalls. A bonus was the placement at the Vikram Sarabhai Space Centre, Thiruvananthapuram. In six years at ISRO, he learnt enough about rocketry to realise he could develop it privately like Space X and Rocket Lab are doing abroad. Quitting ISRO in June 2018, Chandana launched Skyroot along with Naga Bharath Dhaka, 32, also an IIT graduate. Together they began building one of the most cost-effective space launch vehicles in the world. "Step by step, we achieved one milestone after another," says Kumar. Skyroot has raised more than Rs 90 crore as capital and inked a deal to use ISRO test and launch facilities. The start-up has developed cryogenic technology with new propellants, such as liquefied natural gas (LNG) and liquid oxygen (LoX) for the first time in the country. For its stirring success, Skyroot relies on a 100-member team built over the last three and a half years. ■

–Amarnath K. Menon

PRIVATE BOOST Skyroot will launch a satellite using its 20-metre-tall launch vehicle, Vikram-1, before the end of 2022